

Chapter 118_2 - Bastard

Within half a day, they arrived at Wu Mountain.

The last time she had come to this place was during autumn when her heart was filled with despair, but now it was spring morning. The sun had just risen not long ago, revealing half its face among the lush green mountains, casting the town in golden light.

The fragrance of unknown flowers had spread throughout the entire mountain town, mixed with the aroma of food from vendors' stalls, giving one a sense of homecoming.

Jiuying had already taken human form and was threading through the early-rising townsfolk alongside them. She still carried quite a bit of resentment, her thin lips pressed into a straight line.

She bought food from every shop they passed, eating almost from the eastern end of the town to the western end.

The west side was already closest to Wu Mountain, where one could clearly see the mountain covered densely with protective barriers. Presumably due to the incident with Jiang Li, they had greatly increased their defenses, and even a few more sorrowful clouds gathered at the mountain peak.

"Han Ya¹ has not yet sent news, so we need to wait a while. There's a tavern ahead; let's go there," Ning Fuyi said.

"Hey." Jiuying stretched out her hand to pull at her sleeve, holding up her already empty money pouch in front of her.

Ning Fuyi glanced into her pouch, then reached out to cover it and press it down: "You've been eating all along the way. Even the passersby on the road have noticed you. Even if you were hungry for three days, you couldn't eat like this."

"But that's roasted chicken, the last one," Jiuying cast a coquettish glance at her.

"No," Ning Fuyi said firmly. "Let's go."

Watching Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu's backs enter the tavern, Jiuying snorted. Just as she was about to follow, unexpectedly a thin, pale hand extended in front of her, holding a bulging money pouch.

She looked up in surprise, only to see Qiu Yi's gaze still avoiding hers, but holding up the money pouch.

"Oh, you're not afraid of me now?" Jiuying smiled as she took the money pouch. "Fine, I'll consider it borrowed from you. As expected of Divine Venerable's disciple, much more generous than that girl."

She reached out to pinch Qiu Yi's face like pinching a bird, then happily turned to buy roasted chicken, her profile bathed in sunlight.

Qiu Yi placed her hand on her cheek and blinked.

"Two jugs of peach blossom wine," Ning Fuyi said to the shopkeeper, then used her sleeve to wipe down a long bench on one side, looking up at Chu Qingqiu with a smile.

Chu Qingqiu was almost blinded by the light in her eyes, so she lowered her gaze and sat down: "Now can you tell me what you said to the Jiang family? Aren't you afraid they'll notify Penglai Realm² and work together from inside and outside to secretly eliminate you?"

"With Divine Venerable here, how would Penglai dare to move against me?" Ning Fuyi propped her chin and curved her lips.

"I won't save you," Chu Qingqiu said.

"How heartbreaking," Ning Fuyi said insincerely, then took the wine pot from the waiter's hands and filled it for Chu Qingqiu herself. "After your death, I came to Wu Mountain to seek Divine Physician Jiang. I saw that although Jiang family head Jiang Wuying had many restrictions on her, she held great hopes for her, presumably valuing this granddaughter greatly and wouldn't use her life to set a trap."

"As for the content of the letter, it was nothing more than a promise to help her find Jiang Li."

Chu Qingqiu looked at her a few times, then opened her mouth: "Wouldn't it be simpler to directly request an audience in my name?"

Ning Fuyi's mouth opened slightly, then she smiled awkwardly: "I momentarily forgot that Divine Venerable is a righteous person."

Chu Qingqiu looked at her with the expression one would give a pig that couldn't be helped up the wall³. Ning Fuyi hurriedly explained: "But seeking Jiang Li in my name isn't necessarily a bad thing either."

"You want to win over the Four Great Families," Chu Qingqiu understood, saying lightly, "It seems you're not entirely stupid."

Ning Fuyi smiled: "So in Divine Venerable's eyes, I'm very stupid?"

"Drink your wine." Ning Fuyi pushed the wine cup forward.

"I don't touch alcohol," Chu Qingqiu wrinkled her nose and pushed the wine cup away.

Ning Fuyi suddenly remembered the last time she got drunk and mistook herself for Qiu Yi's appearance, causing her to lower her eyes with a smile. Obviously Chu Qingqiu also remembered, as her ears turned light pink.

Just as she was about to say something, Jiuying suddenly walked in from outside, leaning down to whisper in her ear: "Han Ya sent news - the Jiang family agrees to see you."

This news was expected, so Ning Fuyi wasn't surprised. She stood up and walked out of the tavern, only to see a flash of white light beside her, and Chu Qingqiu had already changed her appearance. Though still a cold beauty, her features had changed by eighty percent.

"Divine Venerable, this is..."

"Since you want to help in your name, it would be better if I don't appear," Chu Qingqiu said. She transformed the white bone into a sword and concealed her aura.

"Then how should I address Divine Venerable? As my subordinate, or..." Ning Fuyi's smile grew deeper, earning a raised eyebrow from the woman.

"Partner will do." After saying this, she strode toward Wu Mountain.

Jiuying teasingly bumped Ning Fuyi's shoulder and also strode forward to keep up.

The Jiang family manor had no changes, still permeated with the fragrance of medicinal herbs. Only the immortal servants and Jiang family members coming and going all had stern expressions, and a medicine boy stood at the gate. Upon seeing Ning Fuyi, he bowed and led the group into the manor.

Walking to the depths of the manor, hidden among the bamboo and green shade was a residence where the scent of medicinal herbs was thick.

After crossing two thresholds, they saw in the dim hall a soft couch with someone lying on it. Her face was serious and dignified, her hair bound with a kerchief without ornaments, appearing to be only about forty years old.

But her body was unusually thin, clearly showing she was afflicted with serious illness.

"Ning Fuyi." That person spoke, her gaze sharp as a knife, lingering on Ning Fuyi for several circles, then looking at each of the remaining three people before returning to her.

"I've read your letter. I just never expected you would dare to appear openly before my immortal sect. It seems I've underestimated you somewhat." She chuckled coldly.

"This junior is neither demon nor devil - what is there to fear?" Ning Fuyi smiled without being humble or arrogant.

"That girl Jiang Li is truly disobedient. I tell her to stay by my side, but she refuses. I tell her to associate less with dubious people, but she also refuses." Jiang Wuying played with her long fingernails as she spoke.

"Are you referring to this junior as dubious?" Ning Fuyi didn't hide anything and smiled sweetly.

Jiang Wuying seemed to find this quite interesting and looked at her a few more times: "I've already entrusted my granddaughter's matter to the Six Sects⁴. There's no need for you to interfere. While I haven't changed my mind about notifying Penglai, you should leave quickly."

"Notify Penglai? Before Jiang Li's disappearance, only Penglai, the immortal sects, and my Cowering Hall⁵ people were in the Pill Cauldron Mansion⁶. I'm standing right in front of you now - no need to imprison Jiang Li. The immortal sects have no grudge against Jiang Li - even less need. As the head of the Jiang family, you surely must have guessed in whose hands Jiang Li actually is?" Ning Fuyi said.

Jiang Wuying continued admiring her fingernails but didn't speak again.

Ning Fuyi's gaze swept over the clean room, lingering in the corners for a while, then spoke again: "You love flowers and plants, yet the flowers in several vases have all withered. The sides of the soft couch are too empty, lacking the porcelain bottles that were originally there for decoration - they should have been smashed recently. You agreed to see me precisely because the Six Sects haven't found any clues yet."

"Since you're already anxious as if on fire, there's no need to pretend to be so calm. Each additional day Jiang Li is captured increases her danger by one degree." Ning Fuyi smiled.

Jiang Wuying pressed nail against nail, pushing them into an arc, clearly having her thoughts exposed.

"If my body were still healthy, how could I let someone capture Jiang'er!" Jiang Wuying said hatefully. She pulled out a dragon-headed walking stick from beside the couch and, with the support of an immortal servant, stood up tremblingly.

"I don't care whether you're immortal or demon - as long as you can rescue Jiang'er, you'll be a benefactor to my Jiang family!"

"Being a benefactor isn't necessary. This is what this junior should do. I only ask that in the future, no matter what happens, the Jiang family won't oppose me - that would be sufficient gratitude."

As Ning Fuyi spoke, she raised her hand to draw a formation in the air, then pressed her thumb upon it. The formation emitted a faint pink light.

"Let's establish a contract as proof," she said.

Jiang Wuying's sharp gaze lingered on her for a moment, then spoke to confirm: "The Jiang family has practiced medicine for generations and doesn't participate in martial world disputes. As long as you don't attack my Jiang family, I will definitely honor my promise."

After speaking, she raised her hand to press her fingerprint. The formation turned red, indicating it had taken effect.

Ning Fuyi swept her sleeve to collect the formation and spoke seriously: "Since you agree to let this junior interfere, may I examine that blood letter?"

Jiang Wuying pulled out from under her pillow the blood letter that had been rubbed until it was wrinkled, along with a bloodstained silk sash. She had an immortal servant pass them to Ning Fuyi. After examining them, Ning Fuyi handed them to Chu Qingqiu, who had been observing from the sidelines.

The blood letter only had a twisted, crooked line drawn on it - impossible to tell what character it was meant to be. Even Chu Qingqiu couldn't make out anything from studying it, though her expression showed more worry.

From the looks of it now, Jiang Li's situation wasn't as optimistic as they had thought. This blood letter must have been hastily drawn without even time to write proper characters, suggesting how dire her circumstances must be.

There was also that bloodstained silk sash, which was clearly her magical artifact, but now had no radiance left and had become a piece of waste cloth.

"What character's stroke is this? The character for 'rescue'? Doesn't look like it either!" Jiuying leaned over to study it.

Chu Qingqiu thought quietly for a while, then suddenly pulled Ning Fuyi's sleeve and said softly: "Could it be not a character, but a drawing?"

Ning Fuyi's dark eyebrows moved slightly, then she turned toward Jiang Wuying, who was staring at them, and tentatively spoke: "When this junior last came to Wu Mountain, I heard several people seeking medical treatment discussing a past affair between Young Master Jiang and a woman. I wonder..."

"How is this related to this matter?" Jiang Wuying's gaze instantly turned cold. "I don't know what nonsense those people were spreading, damaging my Jiang family's reputation!"

Ning Fuyi chuckled and pulled over a red sandalwood armchair nearby. Just as she was about to sit down herself, she suddenly remembered something and pushed the chair to Chu Qingqiu beside her.

Footnotes:

1. **Han Ya (寒鸦)** - One of Ning Fuyi's bird-spirit subordinates, whose name literally means "cold crow"
2. **Penglai Realm (蓬莱境)** - One of the major immortal realms, known for its powerful cultivators
3. **A pig that couldn't be helped up the wall** - Chinese idiom meaning someone who is hopeless or unable to improve despite help
4. **Six Sects** - Major immortal cultivation sects that work together on important matters
5. **Cowering Hall (憊畏堂)** - Ning Fuyi's organization/sect
6. **Pill Cauldron Mansion (丹鼎府)** - A location where alchemical activities take place